British company was not beyond resorting to dirty tricks to sabotage its rival.

The two chartered steamers had not been sailing for even two whole months before the contract hit the rocks. It is not clear what were the terms agreed between Shah Line Company and Sena Vana Company, and perhaps that was the source of the disagreement. It is difficult to make out from the newspaper reports and the public exchanges on the issue, whether the steamers were leased, or whether the Tuticorin firm acted as agents.[32] From the *Swadesamitran* reports, under the agreement, valid until 30 September, the Shah Line Company was to pay a commission of 1.5 per cent on its Tuticorin business while each merchant was committed to shipping cargo exclusively on the Shah Line Company steamers on pain of a monthly penalty of Rs 500. The Swadeshi firm was free to stop using the chartered steamers as soon as they acquired their own ships any time after six months from the date of the contract.[33]

Towards the end of August there was news that Essaji Tajbhoy had withdrawn the two chartered ships even though the agreement was valid until 30 September. While the *Swadesamitran* wondered why he would want to withdraw when he was making good money (VOC gives a figure of Rs 20,000 in the very first days[34]), *India* suspected the devious hands of BI. Soon a steamer of the Asiatic Navigation Company arrived at Tuticorin port. But when it too refused to load the Swadeshi cargo, the traders panicked as they were resolved not to return to BI's steamers. The cargo was lifted only after sending a telegram to the Calcutta office of the Asiatic Company. Following this breach of contract, the Swadeshi merchants issued a notice to Essaji Tajbhoy and threatened to sue if the chartered ships were not handed back to them.[35] Three days later, *Swadesamitran* reported that though the Shah Line Company had turned around, the Swadeshi company had decided not to use its services, instead making its arrangements to bring in its own steamer, *Monkseaton* from Colombo (from the Tamil wording it is not clear whether the steamer was being hired or leased or chartered, and from whom).[36]